

# The Trip 1 Paydirt Shortcut

Practice with real gold at your kitchen table before you ever drive to a creek. This is how you know your technique works, so when your pan comes up empty at the river, you know it's the spot and not your hands.

## What paydirt is

**Paydirt** is real gold-bearing gravel, dug from a producing claim and sold in sealed bags. Most bags come with a guaranteed amount of gold. You pan it at home in a tub, exactly like Trip 1 in the workbook, except the "BBs" are real flakes.

It's not a way to make money. A bag usually costs more than the gold inside it. You're paying for practice, certainty, and the fun of seeing your first real color without leaving the house.

## When to use it

| SITUATION                                              | USE PAYDIRT?                                                                 |
|--------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| You finished Trip 1 with BBs and want to try real gold | Yes. Best time to buy your first bag.                                        |
| No creek within driving distance                       | Yes. Do Trips 1, 4 and 5 at home with paydirt (see "Make It Fit Your Life"). |
| Winter, high water, or a rained-out month              | Yes. Keeps your hands in practice.                                           |
| A gift for a kid or a beginner friend                  | Yes. A small bag plus a pan is the classic starter gift.                     |
| You want to get rich                                   | No. Nothing in this hobby does that.                                         |

## How to choose a bag

- ☐ **Guaranteed gold.** Look for a stated minimum amount, and a seller with lots of reviews.
- ☐ **Start small.** A sampler or 1–3 lb bag is plenty for your first sessions.
- ☐ **Real concentrate, not "salted" sand.** Good bags come from actual claims and include black sand, which is perfect practice for Trip 5.
- ☐ **Know what's in it.** Some bags add "pickers" (bigger flakes you can see). Fun, but fine gold is the real test of your technique.

## Where beginners commonly buy

These are well-known sellers that come up again and again in beginner kit reviews. We are not paid by any of them, and prices change, so compare before you buy.

| SELLER                                    | KNOWN FOR                                                                                                                                  |
|-------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| ASR Outdoor (with Bobby Bo paydirt)       | Paydirt from a 3 oz sampler up to 10 lb, plus starter kits with pan, classifier and snuffer bottle. Widely sold on Amazon and TikTok Shop. |
| Klesh Gold                                | Beginner kits with a stated minimum gold amount per bag.                                                                                   |
| Local prospecting shops and GPAA chapters | Often sell their own paydirt, and you can ask questions in person.                                                                         |

## The kitchen-table session (45 minutes)

1. Set up the tub from Trip 1. Fill it with water, wide enough to sink your whole pan.
2. Pour in a quarter of the bag. Don't do the whole bag at once.
3. Run the Trip 1 steps: sink, break up clumps, shake hard under water, tilt riffles-away, wash, re-level, repeat.
4. Stop when you're down to black sand. Switch to the Trip 5 finishing swirl and look for the yellow tail.
5. Snuff every flake into your vial.
6. **Don't dump your tailings.** Pan the leftover tub material a second time. Whatever gold you find there is gold you lost the first time. That's your real score.
7. Write it on a log page: how many flakes in the first pass, how many recovered from the tailings.

### Your target

When your second pass of the tailings finds nothing, your technique is river-ready. Go do Trip 2.

*Ezra says: "We didn't have bags of practice dirt in 1939. We had a bucket, a creek, and a lot of empty pans. Use the bag. Save your knees."*

From First Flake: Josie's 7-Trip Field Workbook. Seller names are listed for convenience only; First Flake has no affiliation with them. Check current prices and reviews before buying.